

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ

الحمد لله والصلاة والسلام على رسول الله وعلى آله وصحبه أجمعين



Tadwīn al-Sunnah Lesson 2 Overview

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Introduction: The Purpose of Studying Tadwīn al-Sunnah

This lesson examines the historical process of **Tadwīn al-Sunnah** (تدوين السنة), meaning the systematic compilation and preservation of the Sunnah of the Messenger of Allāh ﷺ. The objective is not merely to recount historical events, but to clarify widespread misunderstandings surrounding how the Sunnah was preserved, transmitted, and eventually codified into major ḥadīth works. A correct understanding of Tadwīn al-Sunnah removes doubts about the reliability of the Sunnah and demonstrates the depth, rigor, and intentionality of the early Muslim scholarly tradition.

A key premise of the lesson is that the preservation of the Sunnah differs fundamentally from the preservation of the Qur'ān. While the Qur'ān was preserved through **tawātur** and mass memorization under divine guarantee, the Sunnah was preserved through a multi-layered system of memorization, practice, teaching, scrutiny, and later documentation. This difference does not imply weakness, but rather reflects the distinct nature of each source of revelation.

The Nature of the Sunnah and Ḥadīth Classification

The Sunnah consists of the sayings, actions, approvals, and descriptions of the Prophet ﷺ and is classified as **al-waḥy ghayr al-matlūw** (الوحي غير المتلو), revelation that is not recited as Qur'ān but is nonetheless divinely inspired. Because the Sunnah was transmitted through individual narrations, scholars recognized varying levels of authenticity within ḥadīth literature.

As a result, ḥadīth are classified into categories such as **ṣaḥīḥ** (صحيح), **ḥasan** (حسن), and **ḍa'īf** (ضعيف). The existence of weaker narrations does not undermine the Sunnah; rather, it highlights the precision of the scholars who distinguished reliable reports from unreliable ones. Importantly, scholars differed in their **uṣūl** (methodological principles) and in their application of those principles, which explains why jurists and muḥaddithūn sometimes disagreed on whether a specific ḥadīth qualifies as **ḥujjah** (authoritative proof).

Scholarly Ijtihād and Differences in Authentication

The lesson emphasizes that even when scholars agree on foundational principles (**qawā'id**, قواعد), they may differ in application. This is illustrated by examples from **Jāmi' al-Tirmidhī**, where Imām al-Tirmidhī evaluates multiple chains of a single ḥadīth and expresses a preference, while noting that his teacher, Imām al-Bukhārī, preferred a different version. Such differences do not indicate inconsistency but reflect legitimate scholarly **ijtihād**.

The science of authentication is therefore not mechanical. It requires weighing chains, narrators, corroborating evidence, contextual factors, and comparative analysis. When combined with discussions in **uṣūl al-fiqh** and the methodologies of the legal schools (**madhāhib**), it becomes clear that variation in conclusions is both natural and unavoidable. This understanding removes fear and doubt regarding the Sunnah and reinforces confidence in its preservation.

Early Writing and the Meaning of Tadwīn

A central issue addressed in the lesson is the claim that ḥadīth were not written down until the end of the first century. This view persisted for centuries until Imām al-Khaṭīb al-Baghdādī (رحمه الله) systematically addressed it in his work **Taqyīd al-'Ilm** (تقييد العلم). He demonstrated that writing existed during the lifetime of the Prophet ﷺ, the Ṣaḥābah, and the Ṭābi'ūn.

The apparent contradiction arises from differing definitions of **Tadwīn**. Early scholars who stated that Tadwīn began with figures such as **Ibn Shihāb al-Zuhri** (ت ١٢٤-١٢٥ هـ) were not denying earlier writing altogether. Rather, they were referring to **state-sponsored, large-scale, organized compilation**, not personal notes (**ṣuḥuf**, صحف) or limited documentation.

Thus, Tadwīn in their terminology meant systematic, public, and comprehensive compilation, as opposed to individual writing for personal use. This distinction resolves the misconception without accusing earlier scholars of ignorance.

The Role of ‘Umar ibn ‘Abd al-‘Azīz and Institutional Compilation

A turning point in the history of Tadwīn occurred during the caliphate of ‘Umar ibn ‘Abd al-‘Azīz (ت ١٠١ هـ). He issued official instructions to scholars across the **amṣār** (الأمصار, major cities) to record knowledge, fearing its loss due to the passing of scholars. Among those specifically tasked were **Ibn Shihāb al-Zuhri** and **Abū Bakr ibn Ḥazm**.

This initiative marked the first systematic, state-level effort to preserve Islamic knowledge in written form. Importantly, the command encompassed **all transmitted knowledge**, including ḥadīth, fiqh, tafsīr, and reports of the Ṣaḥābah and Tābi‘ūn, since these disciplines had not yet been separated into distinct sciences.

Why Writing Was Initially Discouraged

Imām al-Khaṭīb al-Baghdādī also collected narrations suggesting that writing ḥadīth was discouraged in the earliest period. He reconciled these reports by identifying their underlying rationale. The primary concern was preventing confusion between the Qur’ān and other material and ensuring that new Muslims focused first on memorizing and understanding the Qur’ān.

This concern was especially relevant during a time of rapid Islamic expansion, when many non-Arab populations entered Islam without knowing Arabic. Teaching the Qur’ān and the Arabic language took precedence. This explains statements attributed to ‘Umar ibn al-Khaṭṭāb رضي الله عنه instructing teachers to limit narration and prioritize the Qur’ān.

The discouragement of writing was therefore **contextual**, not absolute or permanent.

Memorization, Writing, and Scholarly Practice

Another reason sometimes cited for early hesitation toward writing was the emphasis on strengthening memorization. Some scholars feared overreliance on

written material might weaken retention. While this rationale existed, it does not fully explain the early reluctance and must be understood within broader historical and pedagogical contexts.

Interestingly, some early scholars would write material to memorize it and then erase their notes once memorization was complete. This practice reflects a pedagogical method rather than opposition to writing itself.

Abū Hurayrah and ‘Abd Allāh ibn ‘Amr: Transmission and Teaching

The lesson discusses the famous comparison between **Abū Hurayrah** رضي الله عنه and **‘Abd Allāh ibn ‘Amr ibn al-‘Āṣ** رضي الله عنهما. Abū Hurayrah stated that no Companion narrated more than him except ‘Abd Allāh ibn ‘Amr, who used to write. Yet historically, Abū Hurayrah transmitted over 5,000 aḥādīth, while ‘Abd Allāh ibn ‘Amr transmitted far fewer.

This apparent paradox is explained by two key factors: accessibility to students and active teaching. Abū Hurayrah resided in Madīnah, taught openly in al-Masjid al-Nabawī, and had numerous students. ‘Abd Allāh ibn ‘Amr lived in relative isolation, limiting the transmission of his knowledge. Knowledge survives through **ta‘līm** (teaching) and **ṭullāb** (students); without them, even vast learning fades.

Conclusion: A Balanced and Accurate Understanding

This lesson establishes that the Sunnah was preserved through a comprehensive, evolving process that combined memorization, practice, scrutiny, teaching, and documentation. Early hesitation toward writing was rooted in wisdom and context, not neglect. Later institutional Tadwīn built upon earlier efforts rather than replacing them.

A proper understanding of Tadwīn al-Sunnah removes doubts, honors the intellectual integrity of early scholars, and affirms that the Sunnah of the Messenger of Allāh ﷺ was preserved with unparalleled care, precision, and sincerity.